

From Adversity to Achievement: An Entrepreneurial Journey of Resilience

A remarkable evidence of resilience, perseverance and power of continuous learning is Deepika Ji, aged 50 who is a resident of **Dharamshala, Himachal Pradesh**. She is an active member of Raashi Shg. Even after facing so many personal and financial challenges, Today she manages her own business of Pickle while simultaneously operating a canteen which makes her earn a stable livelihood for herself and her family. From a very young age life made her learn hard work and abided her with responsibilities towards family. With the unexpected demise of her father who used to run a small grocery store, she had to sacrifice her studies after 8th standard so that she could run the family store for earning livelihood for her three younger siblings while her elder brothers had gone to Mumbai for work.

After getting married also, challenges kept on coming her way as her husband was struggling with alcohol addiction and the family had limited financial resources. So she started rearing cows to sell milk and

other dairy products for the survival needs. Another major breakdown happened when her house of two rooms collapsed because of which the family was forced to create a shelter using mud bricks. Later then, her husband was detected with a serious heart condition forcing him to stay within the house and not work at all. So consequently deepika ji had to become the sole bread earner of the family. Then in the year 2015, the demise of her husband took place due to brain hemorrhage when their 3 children were studying in Class 7, 9 and 10. Despite so many hardships she was determined to make her children graduate, which she successfully achieved as well. She



became a true example of not giving up in life, no matter how hard the situation becomes for you.

The turning point of her life was when she joined shg in 2018 wherein she learnt to make pickles, sheera and badia which became the foundation of her journey of entrepreneurship. She is managing the business on her own and the shg members support her with production activities in return for wages. In the early stages of the journey she was facing the challenge of lack of finance which she overcame with the assistance of Rs 50,000 under the shg scheme offered by the block resulting from which she managed to purchase the necessary raw material for the business.

Her determination of not giving up resulted in another opportunity in 2022 when the opening of Himira canteen at rajiv gandhi college was allotted to her by the block administration. Now she manages both the canteen as well as her pickle business effectively and is able to earn a stable livelihood than before for her family. She gives the credit of her success to the block development officer and chameli madam who continuously guided her on the path of entrepreneurship. However, various challenges still come up, the recent one being the shortage of LPG cylinders which made her consider discontinuing the business, but she still managed it well. The training of entrepreneurship improved her business and personal capabilities. She learnt to use digital payments applications such as google pay, phone pe etc. Earlier she used to fear the usage of smartphones for financial transactions but now she feels confident and handles it well and requires assistance from her children occasionally unlike before. Also, earlier she was selling the products without a label and was unaware of the necessary testing procedures involved. But after attending the training, she was well equipped with the process and understanding about packaging and branding.

Another important improvement that happened is regarding the written records of the business transactions. Earlier she did not use to do any record keeping due to limited understanding but now she documents every aspect of the business such as savings, expenses, profit etc which is enabling her to maintain the business well. She also got encouraged to use Instagram business for expansion, however, she is still learning the mechanism of using social media as a marketing tool but she understands that it's significant for upgrading the business. Apart from these business skills, she also gained self confidence especially in terms of ease in using mobile technology.

Her future vision is to expand her business to a great extent, and aspires to learn more about management of business risks and financial losses. Through her entrepreneurial journey and hardships of life, She learnt that going out of the comfort zone and learning continuously can give a transformative shift to one's life.

In her own words she gives this message to every other women out there,

"dusri mahilaon ko mai ye sandesh dena chahti hu hm soche ki hm garibi mai pade rahe to aisa nahi hai, bahar nikal k bahut kuch seekh jata hai insan, ghar mai hi rehti agar mai ye soch k ki mera kuch ni hona mera gharwala chala gaya hai to jhadu pocha hi kar rahi hoti ghar mai abhi mai aise jee leti hu ki mera apna kaam hai, mai khud kar rhi hu, to mai ye hi bolti hu ladies ko niklo bahar, mai ye bhi hahti hu ki ladies mere pas aae mera kaam seekhe aur aage apna kam kre to ghar mai vaise hi kama skte hai wo."

Her life story inspires and shows everyone that even after facing the financial hardships and losses one can still become the best version of herself with continuous dedication and commitment to succeed. Rather than accepting and being upset over the hardships we get in life, we must work towards finding the solution to it. Her journey has been a remarkable example of not giving up and strengthening women entrepreneurship.